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FRAMING AND PERSISTENT BARRIERS TO THE REINTEGRATION OF FEMALE FORMER COLLABORATORS

A Comparative Study of Sierra Leone and Colombia

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AI Declaration

No AI was used in any way in the writing of this thesis.

Abstract

This thesis aims to analyse the framing assigned to female former collaborators' (FFCs) participation in conflict, and the implication this holds for their experiences of reintegration. This study contributes to critical and feminist conflict studies through its comparison of Sierra Leone and Colombia, two cases with distinct sociocultural-historical, temporal, and geographical contexts, enabling a comparative analysis illustrative of how framings of and barriers to FFCs' reintegration persist across contexts. Sierra Leone and Colombia respectively represent an early and contemporary instance in which United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace, and Security was integrated into disarmament, demobilisation, and reintegration programming with the intention of supporting FFCs' equitable access. The study uses a feminist theoretical framework to analyse institutional documents and testimonies of FFCs. Using a feminist lens provides insight into how institutional rhetoric frames FFCs and their engagement in conflict, and how this coheres or presents a disjuncture with how FFCs frame their lived realities. Using discourse analysis, this is evaluated across fourteen institutional documents pertaining to the countries' respective peace processes, and twenty-four FFC testimonies collected by the countries' respective Truth and Reconciliation Commissions. The results indicate that a disjuncture between institutions' framing of FFCs and their lived realities persists even where policies targeting their support have evolved.

Key words: reintegration; agency; female former collaborators; Sierra Leone; Colombia.

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Spanish to English Translations**Spanish****English**

Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia

Unified Self-Defense Forces of Colombia

Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la
Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repeticiónCommission for the Clarification of Truth,
Coexistence and Non-Repetition

Ejército Popular de Liberación

Popular Liberation Army

Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de
Colombia (- Ejército del Pueblo)Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia
(- People's Army)

La Violencia

The Violence

Movimiento 19 de Abril

19th of April Movement

Abbreviations

AUC	Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia
CDA	Critical Discourse Analysis
CEV	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
DDR	Disarmament, Demobilisation, and Reintegration
EPL	Ejército Popular de Liberación
FARC(-EP)	Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (- Ejército del Pueblo)
FFC	Female Former Collaborator
GBSV	Gender-Based and Sexual Violence
M-19	Movimiento 19 de Abril
RUF	Revolutionary United Front
SLTRC	Sierra Leone Truth and Reconciliation Commission
TRC	Truth and Reconciliation Commission
UN	United Nations
UNAMSIL	United Nations Assistance Mission in Sierra Leone
UNSCR	United Nations Security Council Resolution
WPS	Women, Peace, and Security

1. Introduction

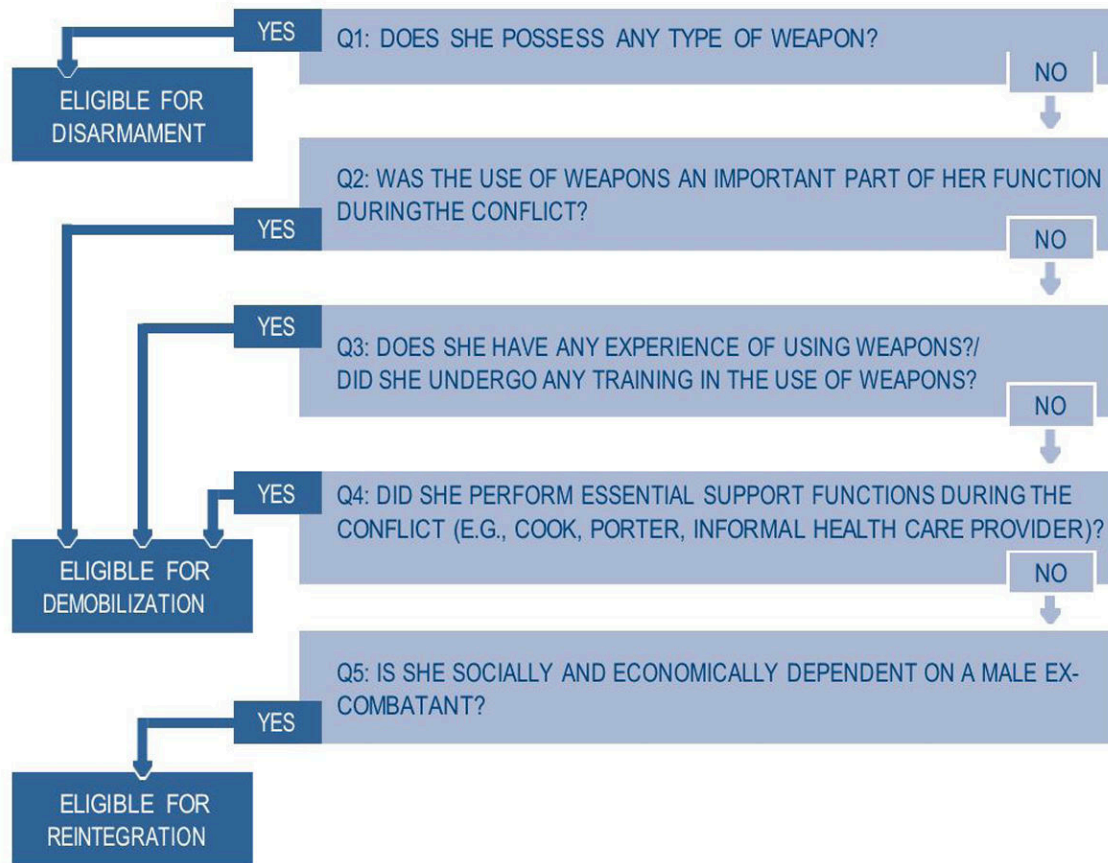
1.1 Aim

The passage of United Nations Security Council Resolution (UNSCR) 1325 on Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) in October 2000 was the first official step taken by the international community to establish and enshrine the dynamism and importance of women's participation across all areas of armed conflict (UNSC, 2000). The resolution was constructed with the understanding that conflict disproportionately impacts women based on, among other things, gender based and sexual violence (GBSV), forced displacement, and increased caring responsibilities (OHCHR, 2021). This has notably worsened in recent years, with the Peace Research Institute Oslo (2025) reporting that more women and girls live in proximity to violent conflict than any other time since the end of the Cold War. Since 2000, the UN has passed an additional ten resolutions on WPS targeting specific concerns. Key here are UNSCR 2122 and UNSCR 2493, which highlight participation and support for women during disarmament, demobilisation, and reintegration (DDR) (UNSC, 2013; UNSC, 2019). These resolutions are collectively referred to as the WPS agenda, and have drawn more attention to the reality that women are not merely victims of conflict, but equally significant to men as perpetrators, diplomats, and peacekeepers (Wan, 2024).

The purpose of this thesis is thus to interrogate whether and to what extent changes to the framing of gender-sensitivity in official reports, statements, and post-conflict policies since UNSCR 1325 are reflected in the experiences of female former collaborators (FFCs). This will be addressed by looking at FFCs' experiences of the reintegration stage of DDR based on its significant, long-term importance for former collaborators. Reintegration is here defined as the attribution of educational, financial, health, and other fundamental resources to former collaborators to support their safe and socioeconomically sustainable (re-)insertion into peaceful livelihood. Resources should not be understood as purely material services, equally encompassing immaterial elements like psychosocial support, and guidance on peaceful co-existence and interpersonal conflict resolution. This definition recognises that reintegration, when defined to include social and psychological dimensions, is not linear, nor does it have an end date, and thus it is something which may require life-long adjustment, such as in cases where an individual is recommended for temporary or permanent relocation due to intracommunity hostility stemming from stigma associated with their former role in conflict.

The term FFC, or female former collaborator, is used to refer to all female-identifying individuals who were associated with any armed group in any capacity for any duration. This definition encompasses all pathways through which FFCs entered conflict, voluntarily or involuntarily, with no path treated differently in terms of one's basic entitlement to services. For instance, in view of Kao and Revkin (2023), a population may, as a collective, involuntarily become collaborators when their territory is invaded by rebels, but diverge over time as some develop social and ideological ties to rebels, while others continue following their directions purely out of fear and necessity. Using an inclusive definition here attempts to create a neutral starting point for understanding FFCs' experiences without prejudice around any pathway to or role within conflict, or the long-term impact this may have on the individual's livelihood or identity.

Importantly, this coheres with the United Nations' (UN) (2021) framework for female DDR eligibility, seen here in *Figure 1*, which indicates the appropriate entry point for FFCs. Since DDR is a sequential process, individuals entering at the appropriate stage are entitled to accessing all subsequent stages. For instance, an FFC who served as a nurse and never held a weapon would be exempt from disarmament, enter demobilisation, and continue through reintegration. The diagram thus clarifies that under UN (2021) guidelines, while not all FFCs may be in need of disarmament and/or demobilisation, all should have access to reintegration.

Figure 1*Female Eligibility for Reintegration (UN, 2021)*

Two comparative case studies will be used, Sierra Leone and Colombia, which respectively represent early and contemporary cases of gender-sensitive reintegration. While DDR and reintegration have been taken up in feminist research, there is minimal scholarship which problematises this topic by comparing highly distinct cases. By contrasting two cases of DDR separated geographically, temporally, and by their sociocultural-historical contexts, this study is well positioned to highlight, where occurring, gendered barriers to reintegration which persist across time and place. Direct accounts of FFCs' experiences with reintegration can provide deeper understandings of how women experience and negotiate life after conflict.

Understanding whether and to what extent there is a disjuncture between institutional rhetoric around gender-sensitivity and inclusivity in reintegration programming compared to FFCs' lived experiences of reintegration is important because it highlights areas of strength and weakness in conventional policymaking pertaining to women's distinct needs. The object of this

thesis is not to imply that others do not experience hardship related to reintegration, for instance men whose experiences as victims are often sidelined due to their presumed masculine aggression. Rather, its purpose is to explore how women have experienced reintegration in the time since their inclusion has become a mainstream element of process development.

A key area which will be explored in this regard is the framing of FFCs as victims of conflict even where they held a perpetrating role. This is a layered and complex issue within reintegration based on standards around the starting point for developing reintegration plans for victims versus perpetrators. Under UN (2022) guidelines, the starting point for perpetrators involves examining their pathway to conflict to develop a plan which minimises their likelihood of re-recruitment. For some, this may involve intensive education and vocational training to provide an economically viable alternative to violence. For others, it may be in the individual's best interest to engage closely in their former armed group's transition to a mainstream political party. Community-oriented provisions for perpetrators' reintegration include anger management courses to help them (re-)learn to interact peacefully with their peers, and locally-driven stigma reduction measures in line with cultural customs.

A significant part of recommendations for victims, on the other hand, focus on opportunities for them and their communities to collectively engage in reconciliation. There is a much heavier focus on victims' community engagement not in the sense of reducing stigma, but in terms of what their communities may collectively need from transitional justice (UN, 2022). As such, assumptions of women's victimhood may prevent them from accessing services normally directed at perpetrators which are vital for their sustainable reintegration.

Building on this point, this thesis aims to contribute policy-relevant findings which can support the development of more targeted, effective DDR processes capable of providing FFCs with equitable resources. Developing a more clear understanding of whether and to what extent FFCs' perspectives on their engagement in conflict and reintegration diverge from the assumptions of institutions here supports such process development by highlighting areas of strength as well as those needing greater attention.

This thesis further aims to contribute to critical feminist scholarship on DDR and peacebuilding by investigating whether and to what extent institutional understandings and lived experiences of gender-sensitive reintegration measures align or present a disjuncture. Contrasting institutional statements with FFCs' testimonies aims to advance understandings of how

discursive framings of WPS implementation vary or cohere with FFCs' lived realities. By comparing an early and contemporary case of WPS-influenced DDR, this thesis examines whether and how a gap between gender-sensitive institutional discourse and reported reintegration experiences persists across distinct contexts.

1.2 Research questions

Primary question

1. What can comparing the Sierra Leonean and Colombian cases reveal about areas of strength and weakness when implementing the WPS agenda in reintegration processes?

Sub-questions

2. How are FFCs in each case framed in institutional discourse?
3. How do FFCs' lived realities reflect or diverge from these findings?

2. Review of Literature

2.1 Disarmament, Demobilisation, and Reintegration

DDR processes first emerged in the 1950s, and have since been established as a leading mechanism of conflict resolution based on their ability to provide former armed group members with the resources and skills needed to make life outside of conflict viable. Early processes, often referred to as “first generation”, mainly focussed on short-term cessation of violence with minimal attention to the root causes of conflict and long-term solutions (Goebel & Levy, 2020). As practitioners increasingly recognised the importance of DDR for peace durability, longer processes emphasising reintegration became favoured, known as “second generation” DDR (Goebel & Levy, 2020). The UN now recommends longer mission mandates, aiming to increase community-based capacity building to support locals after DDR has finished, measures collectively referred to as “third generation” processes (Goebel & Levy, 2020).

DDR typically takes place in three sequential stages. The first, disarmament, involves the laying down of weapons by all former collaborators, signifying a commitment to the dissolution of armed groups and return to peace (UN DPO, 2010). Demobilisation follows, entailing former collaborators’ placement in demobilisation camps to receive health screenings and begin developing skills needed to safely return to community life (UN, 2021). The final stage, reintegration, is recognised as the longest and most complex stage, the success or failure of which corresponds to some of the most significant known correlates to violent relapse, including economic strain and social stratification (Collier et al., 2003). While former armed group members are not entirely self-sufficient, remaining supported through funding and shelter, reintegration marks the first meaningful step towards their independence. This may involve returning to their community of origin, or settlement into a new area if returning home is unsafe or otherwise undesirable (UNDP, 2012).

As Goebel and Levy (2020) explain, third generation DDR processes theoretically carry the advantage of positioning former armed group members with long-term employment, social support, and a sense of trust towards their neighbours and communities, factors which together reduce their likelihood of returning to conflict. Ayissi (2020) cautions, however, that despite policy evolution, many processes remain focussed on disarmament and demobilisation, neglecting reintegration. This contradicts both conventionally accepted best practices and international standards, presenting a scholarly and policy dilemma.

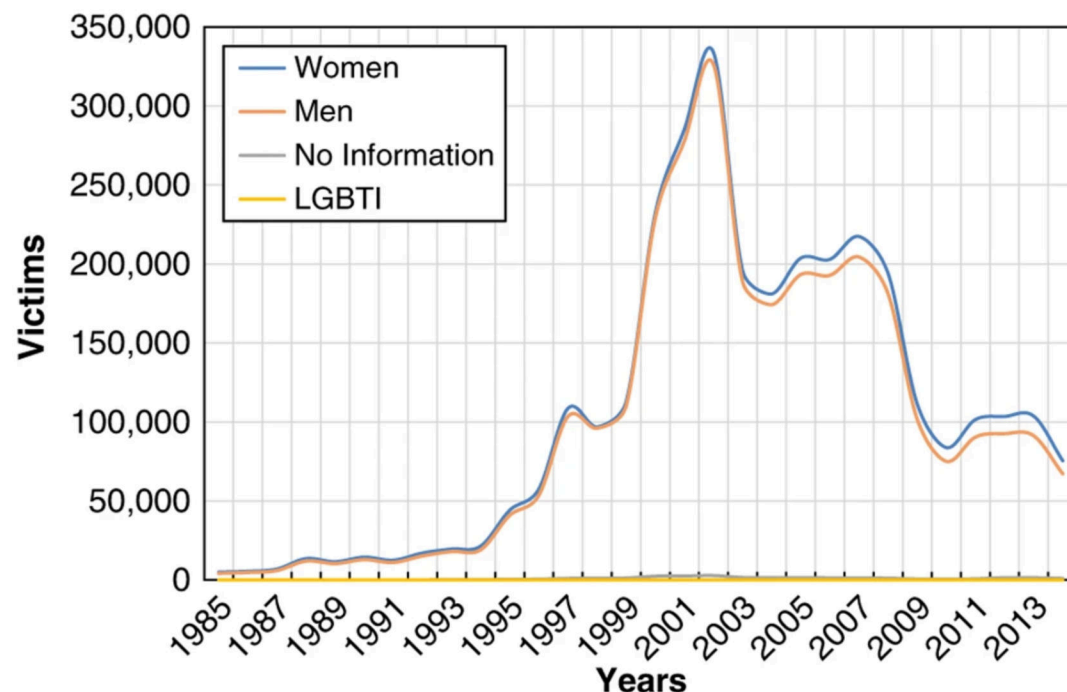
2.2 Women, Peace, and Security

Implementing WPS has seen mixed success across different areas of peace operations. The UN DPO (2022) notes that as of 2022, women's participation across peace operations had seen significant growth, although Tarnaala and Solanas (2025) caution that certain areas have seen consistent decline since 2020. For instance, women participated in 80% of UN-directed peace negotiations in 2022, yet their representation as a percentage of total delegates and mediators remains as low as 1.5% (Tarnaala & Solanas, 2025). Newby and O'Malley (2021) additionally find that while early WPS resolutions made critical strides concerning GBSV, their use of language perpetuating women's victimhood has distracted from the participatory side of the WPS agenda. In view of Sjoberg and Gentry (2007), such depictions perpetuate a view of women's role in conflict as exclusively one of victimhood, stripping them of their agency and consequently their ability to seek support.

Essentialising women's role in this way holds those affected by war back from receiving proper support, but also from facing justice for their role as perpetrators. In Colombia, for instance, *Figure 2* demonstrates that women and men are almost equally victims of conflict (Restrepo, 2016).

Figure 2

Female and Male Victims of Conflict in Colombia from 1985-2013 (Restrepo, 2016)



The generalisability of this observation is supported by Kreft and Agerberg's (2024) study of how ordinary people conceive of men's victimhood and vulnerability during violent conflict, the findings of which suggest that men's victimisation is underestimated and its severity minimised. The binary gendered portrayal of male perpetrators and female victims thus contributes to the erasure of men's victimhood, including at the hands of women. Failing to recognise the violence FFCs perpetrate as equal to that inflicted by men suggests their victims' suffering is somehow lesser, potentially displacing them from access to justice, which van den Berg (2023) identifies as a persistent challenge for "ordinary" (non-exceptional; low-rank) individuals (Gentry & Sjoberg, 2015).

2.3 FFCs and DDR

Enrolling in DDR has historically been a challenge for FFCs, primarily based on the fact that they often hold unarmed roles, serving as spies, cooks, or porters rather than being positioned near the front lines of conflict (Holmgren, 2009). While it is established under UN (2019; 2021) standards that DDR eligibility assessments should be based on former collaborators' knowledge of the conflict, such as high-ranked officials' names, practitioners are known to rely on traditional assessment methods based around weapons skills. Eligibility assessments are vital to prevent non-collaborators from enrolling for the purpose of claiming subsistence benefits and ensure individuals guilty of mass atrocities are separated and put to justice (UN, 2021). However, with only an estimated one-fifth to one-third of FFCs being trained to handle weapons, constructing assessments around such skills poses an often insurmountable barrier (Holmgren, 2009; Solomon & Ginifer, 2008). This persistently leads to low female participation rates, with recent estimates suggesting that at most, only half of eligible women and girls enrol in DDR (GIWPS, 2025; Mesa, 2023).

This approach places disproportionate focus on disarmament, the main purpose of which, other than collecting weapons, is reducing security dilemmas between former armed factions and building confidence in the peace process (UN, 2020). While vital, such assurances alone cannot create durable peace. Rather, demobilisation and especially reintegration play the most important role in dismantling barriers to peace (UN, 2021; UN, 2022). The majority of DDR is thus unrelated to whether an individual was armed or unarmed, emphasising the insufficiency of relying on weapons handover for enrolment despite regulations stipulating more inclusive criteria to support unarmed collaborators.

In addition to ensuring FFCs can enrol in reintegration, it is vital that their inclusion does not take an “add women and stir” approach, and is constructed in a manner which recognises and accounts for individuals’ unique involvement as perpetrators, victims, or somewhere in between. Annan et al. (2011) and Henshaw (2017) argue that FFCs are the most in need of reintegration due to the stigma associated with their status, with their exclusion potentially causing long-term challenges. Social challenges including stigma, as Annan et al. (2011) identify, may also increase perpetrators’ odds of returning to violence, further emphasising the danger posed to FFCs assumed to be victims. Hauge (2020) argues this continues to be a problem due, at least in part, to a persistent disconnect between academic literature and policymaking, the bridging of which could open more favourable opportunities concerning female perpetrators.

On top of ensuring their reintegration plans contain necessary provisions guided by the nature of their involvement, recognising the dynamism of FFCs’ roles can contribute to their long-term social outcomes. In Northern Uganda, Annan et al. (2011) found that perpetrators faced greater social reinsertion challenges when returning to their families and communities, which further increased for female perpetrators. The authors notably do not define perpetrated acts of violence based only on whether one was armed, which emphasises the importance of treating individuals’ experiences as unique rather than making assumptions about their role or needs based on their weapons skills. Particularly in view of the observation Cohen (2013) makes based on interviews with Sierra Leonean former collaborators that female perpetrators favoured methods of extreme violence, the pertinence of recognising violent women equally becomes clear. This argument is further supported by Humphreys and Weinstein’s (2007) finding that the degree of abuse committed by collaborators, where abuse is again not limited only to violence inflicted through weapons, has a profound impact on their social reintegration.

Focussing on demobilisation and reintegration in Sierra Leone, Humphreys and Weinstein’s (2007) findings further suggest that an individual’s political ties to their armed group and pathway to conflict (voluntary versus forced) were significant factors in determining how and from whom collaborators would seek assistance, irrespective of their gender. The authors identified these factors as significant determinants of collaborators’ social reintegration success, where those who voluntarily joined armed groups due to ideological congruence faced greater barriers. This suggests that making assumptions about FFCs primarily based on their gender, rather than their engagement in conflict, may interfere with their ability to access appropriate

resources. Building on this argument, this research aims to highlight the diversity of FFC experiences to emphasise where entrenched assumptions of their victimhood contrasted to men's violence may prove insufficient and infringe upon their access to appropriate support.

3. Theoretical Framework

The inclusion of gender-sensitive measures in post-conflict policymaking has been mandated since the adoption of UNSCR 1325. While progress has been made, challenges remain concerning the translation of policy into practice during DDR, with FFCs bearing the cost of this stagnation.

This chapter introduces the theoretical framework through which this problem will be analysed. A feminist lens forms the backbone of this thesis, the suitability of which comes from feminists' desire to challenge binary constructs which limit the roles, characteristics, and expectations assigned to women. Gentry and Sjoberg (2015) aptly summarise the point of departure for feminist and gendered analyses of conflict, asserting "[f]eminists do not claim that all women are innocent, or that women's violence should be blamed on men's oppression. Instead, feminist scholarship uses gender as a category of analysis to complicate ideas of agency, interdependence and criminality." Following this definition, this chapter provides an introduction to relevant analytical frames and their application in this research.

3.2 "Mothers, Monsters, Whores"

The tendency in conventional conflict studies and policymaking has long been to emphasise the role of coercion and terror in women's participation in conflict. To assess the validity of this assumption and how women's participation aligns with or contradicts this framing, it is useful to draw on the "Mothers, Monsters, Whores" framework developed by Sjoberg and Gentry (2007). The authors use these categories to describe the most common framings of women's roles in conflict, and explain how they reduce FFCs' varied realities. The "Mothers" frame relies on assumptions of women's inherent pacificity to assert that any deviant behaviour must be accountable to their role as the protectors of loved ones. Women for whom such a selfless motivation cannot be identified are in turn labelled "Monsters", implying the impossibility of their participation in violence being a rationalised political decision and suggesting instead that a pathology is to blame. Finally, women may be dubbed "Whores" when their engagement in violence is framed in relation to promiscuity or sexual manipulation at the hands of men.

Perpetuating a view that FFCs are either victims or deviants contributes to the stigma associated with their former collaborator status and difficulties faced upon community (re-)insertion. This is a particularly pronounced challenge for FFCs, including children, who

became mothers as a result of the conflict. Often identified as “Whores”, these individuals are known to struggle with reintegration due to insufficient childcare and healthcare, and the attribution of their stipends to the men in their lives (Denov & Marchand, 2014; Mazurana & Carlson, 2004). Moreover, the stigma associated with this status creates what Mutsonziwa et al. (2020) refer to as “another form of captivity” wherein FFCs continue to face marginalisation, displacement, and discrimination in supposed peacetime. This heightens the isolation, rejection, and socioeconomic precarity associated with their status.

3.2.2 Application

When applying Sjoberg and Gentry’s (2007) analytical ideal types of “Mothers, Monsters, Whores” to reintegration in Sierra Leone and Colombia, it is expected that policymakers’ conscious or unconscious use of these frames will create a narrow understanding of how women engage in conflict. This will be evaluated by considering where discussions of women arise in texts, for instance whether they are referred to alongside male collaborators or discussed as a population whose rights have been violated. Where the former indicates a more neutral starting point for FFCs’ reintegration access, the latter suggests their inclusion begins from the assumption of their victimhood.

Applications of these frames may also be identified through discussions of women’s post-conflict realities. If women’s issues are largely discussed in tandem with their need to provide for their children, this may support the use of the “Mothers” frame by foregrounding women’s caring nature over their actions during conflict. The “Mothers” frame closely connects as well to discourse on women’s empowerment through conflict, and may be used to promote an image of brave women whose actions were borne out of necessity rather than political or violent mobilisation, and who have since established themselves as leaders for other women. This may suggest a reintegration approach more comparable to that offered to victims based on the emphasis of community-based measures. Discussions placing greater centrality on particularly egregious and violent actions of women, where women are specifically singled out and not discussed alongside other former collaborators, may on the other hand indicate reliance on the “Monsters” or “Whores” frames depending on the nature of these behaviours. This, in turn, may suggest that FFCs’ reintegration plans start from the assumption that they are perpetrators of violence based on the frames’ emphasis of deviant behaviour.

FFCs' testimonies, on the other hand, are expected to demonstrate that women's lived realities contain more nuance than simple labels can capture. Their rigidity drives an assumption that, for instance, an FFC could not be both drawn to violence out of greed or grievance ("Monsters") *and* in the interest of their loved ones' wellbeing ("Mothers"). An example where this may apply is a single mother seeing both a path out of poverty in the ambitions of a guerrilla group, and a way to protect her children through the sense of security, even family, armed group members report finding (Marin, 2008). This could similarly apply to an FFC who was initially coerced into conflict and taught to commit violence by a male partner ("Whores") but over time gained interest in the political message of her armed group, continuing to engage as an outlet to fight for her beliefs ("Monsters"). Feminist researchers do not deny that some FFCs join armed groups purely out of desperation to protect themselves and their loved ones. Instead, it is argued that *assuming* FFCs are "Mothers" until proven otherwise contributes to the erasure of their involvement, and consequently their ability to seek support.

3.3 "womenandchildren"

In popular discussions of peace and conflict, there has long been a tendency to group women's (non-)participation with that of children, a reality which contributed to Cynthia Enloe's (1990) coining of the term "womenandchildren" to describe the uniformity of victimhood assigned to both groups. More recent scholarship such as that of Vaittinen (2018) has extended this framing to include "womenandchildren-and-thedisabledrest" to capture how individuals not fitting the ideal-typical template of combatancy are discursively made hyper-vulnerable through their appearance, in contrast to how, for instance, the vulnerability of an able-bodied adult male conflict victim becomes obscured by his 'threatening' appearance.

When looking at FFCs, this framing may contribute to the sense of victimhood and lack of agency associated with their identity. Children involved in conflict are recognised by the UN (2017) as victims due to the disproportionate impact of violence on their mental and physical health, relationships, and future livelihoods, and to facilitate their access to tailored support. Automatically recognising adult women in the same way, however, contributes to challenges regarding their accountability and access to appropriate reintegration resources. This argument does not seek to diminish the identity as victims FFCs may feel due to the coercion, GBSV, and displacement many experience as a result of conflict, rather serving as a reminder that adult women are rational agents whose gender does not *inherently* make them victims.

Popularising the idea that FFCs are childlike and lack the knowledge or rationality to make independent decisions may contribute to difficulties for which they consistently report receiving inadequate support. Denov and Marchand (2014) for instance found that funding and childcare were withheld from single mother FFCs in Colombia, preventing them from working. Mazurana and Carlson (2004) further found that in Sierra Leone, while policy gave all former collaborators access to an educational or vocational training path of their choosing, FFCs were prevented by practitioners from participating in those viewed traditionally as ‘masculine’. As Mohanty (2003) explains, popular discursive framings often speak to women’s ‘problems’ and ‘needs’ while sidelining their freedom to make *choices*. In this way, the perceived difference of FFCs’ needs and the obligation to fulfil them can be seen as an extension of the denial that they are rational, agentic actors equal to male collaborators.

3.3.2 Application

Presentations of “womenandchildren” in institutional documents may indicate the sense of vulnerability and helplessness which policymakers perceive, consciously or unconsciously, when considering FFCs’ experiences. It is expected that where women are largely referenced in connection to children, their agency may be diminished based on the implication that they are not equal, rational actors. This framing, where identified, would equate children, whose recruitment into conflict is a war crime, to women, whose engagement in conflict can be forced, but can equally be a rational decision. Uses of this frame would suggest that FFCs’ reintegration plans begin from the assumption that they are victims, as the frame indicates their association with children, who are automatically considered victims (UN, 2017). Another indicator would be whether discussions of women’s circumstances occur as a standalone topic, alongside those of men, or in relation to children. Discussions of FFCs in relation to their dependents, for instance the provision of childcare, will not be classified as depictions of “womenandchildren”, as it would be unreasonable to treat discussions of support offered to mothers as infantilising.

FFCs testimonies, in contrast, are expected to demonstrate that they are rational, agentic individuals with varying reasons for joining an armed group. Reliance on these frames in institutional documents is expected to create narrow imaginations, the adequacy of which will be challenged through the more diverse experiences of FFCs. Including where women describe being forced to engage in conflict, their testimonies are expected to highlight their thought

processes and the choices they made both during and after conflict, demonstrating greater agency and awareness than their being categorised alongside children may otherwise imply.

4. Case Studies

4.1 Sierra Leone

4.1.1 *The Sierra Leonean Civil War (1991-2002)*

The Sierra Leonean civil war began in 1991 between the Revolutionary United Front (RUF) and All People's Congress (Jang, 2012). Domestically, discontent was growing regarding the deep entrenchment of corruption within the government, which prevented state institutions from delivering basic services to citizens (Collier & Duponchel, 2012). In the years leading up to the conflict, the economy effectively collapsed, creating massive unemployment particularly impacting youth, whose discontent led to exceptionally high recruitment rates.

Citizens' grievances were compounded by regional instability, notably the onset of civil war in Liberia, then led by Charles Taylor (Bøås, 2005). The RUF capitalised on Liberia's instability for personal gain, making a deal with Taylor regarding the countries' border region, which is rich in natural resources (Jang, 2012). For Taylor, this created interest in a destabilised Sierra Leone insofar as it could facilitate easier Liberian access to resources and their wealth (Jang, 2012). It was from this region that the first attacks were launched by the RUF, aiming to overthrow the government (UNAMSIL, 2005b).

4.1.2 *DDR in Sierra Leone*

Beginning in 1998, DDR took place in three phases, each separated by brief violent relapses and characterised by policy evolution (Solomon & Ginifer, 2008). Most notably here is the third phase, which ran from May 2001 to January 2002, and was one of the first to integrate WPS principles. This is the phase on which analysis will focus to ensure conclusions relating to WPS measures are not drawn unfairly from data predating the WPS agenda.

A key development of this phase was the United Nations Assistance Mission in Sierra Leone's (UNAMSIL) refinement of enrolment criteria, which no longer required each individual to hand over a weapon, and allowed groups of collaborators to enrol together (Donnaint, 2021). While this encouraged some improvement in women's participation rates, less was done to mitigate intangible concerns including fear of reprisal and lack of personal identity documents (Mazurana & Carlson, 2004). Some women also reported that after enrolling in DDR, they felt forced to withdraw as they were not provided essential supplies like feminine hygiene products at demobilisation camps. Using data provided by research institutions and UNAMSIL's DDR

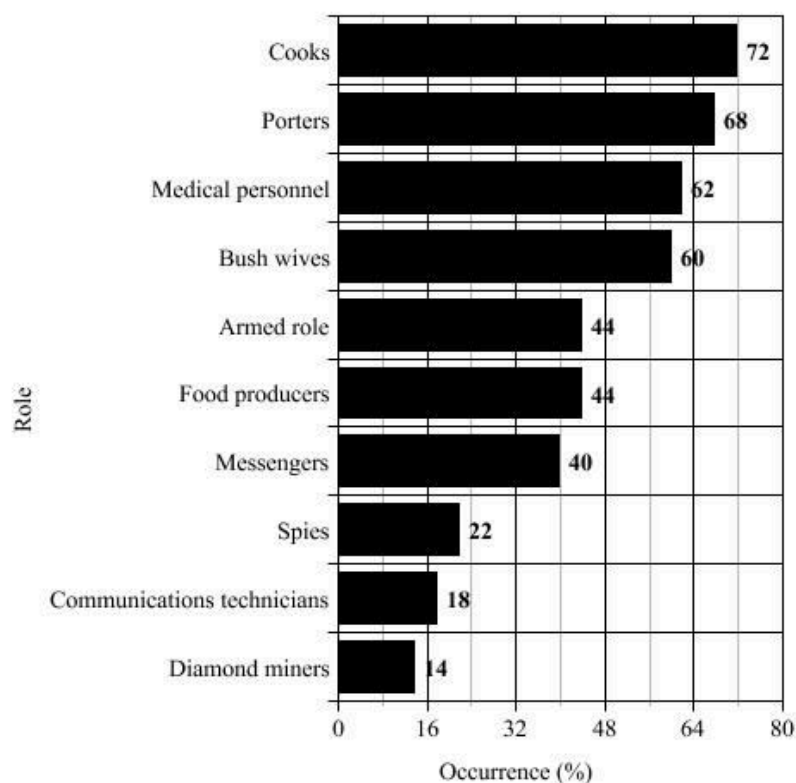
statistics, academics estimate that 76.5% of eligible women and 88% of eligible girls were unable to enrol in DDR, where eligibility is based on individuals' socioeconomic dependence on or active engagement in any armed group (Donnaint, 2021; Ekiyor & Wanyeki, 2008).

4.1.3 FFCs in Sierra Leone's DDR Process

The significance of UNAMSIL's failure to equitably include FFCs in DDR is amplified by the scale and severity of harm they experienced during the conflict. Girls in particular faced atrocities on an unprecedented scale, with children as young as two years of age being kidnapped and placed on the front lines of conflict as young as seven (Betancourt et al., 2010). Amongst these individuals, Betancourt et al. (2010) found 99% became involved in the conflict through abduction, and constituted up to 80% of armed group personnel (Save the Children, 2000). Based on interviews conducted with FFCs, Mazurana and Carlson (2004) found that FFCs held a variety of roles, which are illustrated in *Figure 3*.

Figure 3

Role(s) held by Sierra Leonean FFCs¹



¹ The data used to construct this graph was sourced from Mazurana and Carlson (2004, p. 12). Figures reflect that FFCs often held multiple roles simultaneously and/or over the course of the conflict.

The number of FFCs led to increased attention to their unique position within conflict, including how gender norms and sexual exploitation connect to other roles such as cooking or spying they were expected to execute within armed groups (Ben-Ari, 2014). For instance, one woman recounted to the Sierra Leone Truth and Reconciliation Commission (SLTRC) (2004a) that when the RUF arrived at her village to kidnap more recruits, they arbitrarily selected women to accuse of plotting against their leader and subjected them to violence and torture.

Estimates indicate that 217 000 to 257 000 women and girls faced similar violence, although these figures are likely higher, as many were prevented from reporting their experiences due to fear, stigma, and/or coercion (Physicians for Human Rights, 2002). With the majority of FFCs prevented from accessing DDR, most became reliant on community-based or peer-to-peer resources (Donnaint, 2021; Ekiyor & Wanyeki, 2008; Betancourt et al., 2008). While vital, such programmes have been proven to be insufficient as they lack expert knowledge, particularly in the area of psychosocial support for traumatised former collaborators (Betancourt et al., 2008; Solomon & Ginifer, 2008). Long term, service inadequacy may contribute to increased substance abuse, self-harm, domestic abuse, and intergenerational trauma (Ornert, 2019).

4.2 Colombia

4.2.1 The Colombian Civil War (1946-present)

Protracted conflict has characterised Colombia's political landscape for 80 years. DDR has been attempted several times, with the latest process initiated following the 2016 peace accord being the focus of this study. Conflict began in 1946 with clashes between Conservative and Liberal party members over land rights (von der Walde & Burbano, 2001). By 1948, followers of each party had established armed groups, marking the start of *La Violencia*, a decade-long period of violence which culminated in the world's first DDR process (von der Walde & Burbano, 2001; Kaplan, 2024). While successful in disarmament and demobilisation, the programme proved unable to address entrenched socioeconomic disparities.

The period after *La Violencia* brought some stability between original adversaries, but by then, conflict had spread far beyond these groups (von der Walde & Burbano, 2001). The 1960s subsequently saw the rise of highly influential armed groups whose existence would come to shape the country's conflict for decades to come, notably including the *Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia – Ejército del Pueblo* (FARC-EP), *Ejército Popular de Liberación* (EPL), and *Movimiento 19 de Abril* (M-19). Several attempts at peace processes and DDR were

made, though all were abandoned within a few years; in fact, the *Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia* (AUC) was more interested in *increasing* national armament, coercing civilians into forming counter-insurgent paramilitary organisations and providing them with arms (Medina & Özmen, 2020).

4.2.2 The 2016 Peace Agreement and DDR

Colombia's most recent DDR process began in November 2016, under a week after the peace agreement was passed (Fernández-Osorio & Pachón-Pinzón, 2019). Between 2016 and 2025, at least 13 000 former FARC-EP members entered DDR (UNSC, 2025a). These individuals joined the 55 000 former collaborators, most of whom had fought for the AUC and guerrilla groups other than the FARC-EP, who had voluntarily enrolled in DDR since 2002 under a government incentivisation programme (Kaplan & Nussio, 2016). To date, the process has widely been seen as a success and model for future DDR processes, including due to its high rate of weapons collection and the UN's role in increasing trust and support in the process. Others raise warnings, however, around the slow implementation of the peace agreement and heightened violence in previously peaceful regions (HIIK, 2024; GIWPS, 2025).

4.2.3 FFCs in Colombia's DDR Process

The Colombian peace agreement has received significant praise for its integration of gender-sensitivity, particularly based on the acknowledgement and attribution of targeted provisions to support Indigenous, young, and rural women who may face additional barriers (National Authorities, 2016). Others, however, remain critical of this aspect, questioning whether the agreement can truly be seen as a success in inclusivity when, as of November 2025, 87% of agreed-upon measures aiming to support FFCs had not been implemented (GIWPS, 2025). Torres-Acosta (2024) notes that FFC exclusion from DDR persists in Colombia, arguing that even where they are able to participate, women face marginalisation, largely due to insufficient consultation and coordination between policymakers and FFCs. This is supported by findings from the GIWPS (2025) and Mesa (2023) which suggest that at most, 50% of eligible FFCs are participating in DDR. The authors draw this estimate from gender-disaggregated data collected by the National Agency for Reincorporation and Normalisation, contrasting their census data on registered DDR participants with that outlining armed group demographics collected after the

2016 peace agreement by the Council on Foreign Relations (Departamento Nacional de Planeación, 2018 in Mesa, 2023; Bigio et al, 2017 in GIWPS, 2025).

The danger of excluding FFCs from Colombia's DDR process is exacerbated by the scope and scale of their involvement in the conflict. Colombian FFCs have been studied as a unique group based on how many women participated and the range of roles they were assigned, with an exceptional number serving in traditionally male roles, including on the front lines of conflict (Gutiérrez & Murphy, 2022). In spite of this reality and the inclusion of overarching gender-sensitive measures in the peace agreement, no mechanisms for FFCs' reintegration have been developed. Neira-Cruz and Ortiz-Acosta (2026) additionally note that justice and support systems have failed to recognise gendered crimes unrelated to sexual violence, such as domestic and economic abuse, contributing to FFCs' persistent exposure. Insufficient gender-sensitive measures place not only FFCs at risk, but Colombian stability at large, as their non-engagement leaves a significant segment of the population without the support and tools needed to reintegrate, including mentally and ideologically, into civilian life, factors known to encourage a return to violence (Collier et al., 2003). The DDR process has now been active for nearly a decade, rendering this lack of progress dangerous for FFCs' physical, emotional, and socioeconomic wellbeing.

5. Methodology

5.1 Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA)

5.1.1 Defining CDA

The approach to CDA taken in this thesis follows that developed by Jäger (2011), which uses as its point of departure the assumption that knowledge is subjectively determined by human experiences, past and present, which create diverse discursive contexts. These discursive contexts, in turn, provide the basis upon which knowledge in its geographic and temporal context can be understood and critiqued. Discourses may change or evolve over time, and come together to develop an individual's imagination and understanding of their sociopolitical context, allowing them to understand others' realities in relation to their own. Jäger (2011) notably adds that discourses are not pure, unbiased reflections of reality, but rather "live a life of their own". This does not make discourse any less 'real' or influential, rather serving as a reminder of the need to think critically about what may be promoted or marginalised in one's own discursive context.

CDA distinguishes itself from other forms of discourse analysis by asserting that while the selection of language and phrasing may be conscious or unconscious, it is never neutral, and thus serves to form and legitimate (unequal) power dynamics and sociopolitical inequalities (Mullet, 2018). Constructs developed through discourse become taken for granted in their respective contexts, shaping how individuals perceive their own realities and understand those of others. CDA seeks to understand how these relations are negotiated and shaped by those in possession of power and the implications consequently attributed to certain individuals or groups. This allows for the reproduction of hierarchies and relations of dominance/subjugation between groups, here discussed as applicable to DDR policymakers seated in positions of power juxtaposed against FFCs whose reintegration trajectories are shaped by policymakers' decisions. CDA follows the assumption that the contextual uniqueness of a given strand of discourse allows multiple discursive realities to co-exist in a given place and time (Jäger, 2011).

CDA seeks to analyse written and spoken language, as well as any visual or non-dialogical elements of sound which accompany a text. In this case, it will focus on written or transcribed texts relevant to each case. Two categories of text will be analysed: institutional documents relevant to each DDR process; and FFC testimonies presented to either the SLTRC or Colombia's *Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición*

(CEV). The remainder of this section will explore how documents were selected, and detail their analytical purpose.

5.1.2 Sampling

The selection of texts followed a purposive sampling strategy, defined by Palys (2008) as choosing items for analysis based on the objective of the research project. Since this research involves multiple types of texts, the sampling procedure for each type of text was slightly different based on their respective purposes.

Institutional documents were selected with the purpose of illuminating institutional narratives and perspectives relevant to the development and framing of gender-sensitive DDR. Seven documents per case were selected. Documents must have been directly developed and published by a UN entity, for instance the Security Council, based on the UN's verifiable influence over DDR policy and implementation. Texts must have been published on an official basis, entailing the elimination of, for instance, statements made by practitioners on an independent basis as opposed to as a representation of their employer. References to gender or FFCs were not used as exclusion criteria based on the understanding that the absence or erasure of a group and its perspective is itself a discursive element within CDA (Slemon, 2025).

To identify documents, I first used the University of Cambridge and United Nations Mediation and Support Unit's (2016) *Language of Peace* database. The database has been continually updated since it was first developed in 2016, and is considered a leading resource for peace research as it contains thousands of documents relating to every known peace process conducted since 1945 (Peace Palace Library, 2020). This includes peace agreements, ceasefire declarations, and mediation reports, providing a strong starting point for this research.

When searching for Sierra Leonean documents, only those published after UNSCR 1325 was passed were considered, providing four results. For Colombia, only documents published since the 2016 peace agreement were selected to ensure their relevance to the ongoing DDR process and not an earlier one. This provided ten results. These documents were then used to locate additional relevant items which had been cited or suggested would be forthcoming. I then assessed and selected documents based on their ability to provide analytical breadth. The documents ultimately selected come from a range of UN entities and possess credible authority, engagement, and influence with respect to each country's peace process. As official publications, they reflect the perspective the UN seeks to disseminate to the public and its partner agencies

about their engagement and priorities. All documents have been assigned a code, the format for which can be found in *Figure 4* alongside a breakdown of publication information.

Figure 4

Institutional Documents for Analysis

Code²³⁴	Document	Year	Source
SL-SG1	Eleventh report of the Secretary-General on the United Nations Mission in Sierra Leone	2001	United Nations Secretary-General
SL-RES1	Resolution 1346 (2001)	2001	United Nations Security Council
SL-SG2	Thirteenth report of the Secretary-General on the United Nations Mission in Sierra Leone	2002	United Nations Secretary-General
SL-SG3	Fifteenth report of the Secretary-General on the United Nations Mission in Sierra Leone	2002	United Nations Secretary-General
SL-RES2	Resolution 1436 (2002)	2002	United Nations Security Council
SL-SG4	Sixteenth report of the Secretary-General on the United Nations Mission in Sierra Leone	2002	United Nations Digital Library
SL-MSIL1	Fact sheet 1: Disarmament, Demobilization and Reintegration	2005	United Nations Department of Peacekeeping Operations
CO-SG1	Report of the Secretary-General on the United Nations Mission in Colombia	2017	United Nations Secretary-General
CO-SC1	Security Council press statement on Colombia following UN Security Council Colombia session July 2024	2024	United Nations Security Council
CO-SC2	Public statement by chair of working group on children and armed conflict	2024	United Nations Security Council

² Codes for official publications are formatted as: [abbreviated country name]-[abbreviated document type + number].

³ Country names are abbreviated as: SL (Sierra Leone), CO (Colombia).

⁴ Document types are abbreviated as: MSIL (report of UNAMSIL), SG (report of the UN Secretary-General), SC (statement of the UN Security Council), RES (UN Security Council Resolution), FEM (statement of UN Women).

CO-SC3	As 8-year mark of Colombia's peace agreement nears, speakers in Security Council highlight women's role in driving implementation	2024	United Nations Security Council
CO-RES1	Resolution 2754 (2024)	2024	United Nations Security Council
CO-FEM1	The peace deal that put women first: What Colombia taught the world	2025	UN Women
CO-SG2	United Nations Verification Mission in Colombia: Report of the Secretary-General	2025	United Nations Secretary-General

The second form of text used was FFC testimonies, which were collected by the SLTRC and CEV. Twelve testimonies per case were selected. The CEV (2022) published the 25 testimonies it collected from women and members of the LGBTQI+ community in a distinct chapter of the Commission's report. The SLTRC (2004a; 2004b) did not publish a similar chapter, instead including testimonies in its appendices. To identify those delivered by women and girls, I searched in-text for uses of female pronouns (she/her) and titles (Miss/Madam). Each testimony included a brief preface about the speaking individual which was typically where their gender could be ascertained, in a statement such as "she was sworn on oath by [commissioner]". In other cases, it was identifiable by the title listed in the testimony transcript. This resulted in 31 testimonies from women and girls.

Purposive sampling in this case used witnesses' status as FFCs as its primary exclusion criterion. This was assessed based on the individual's discussion of their experience during conflict. For instance, an individual who described fleeing the country soon after the outbreak of conflict would have been excluded, as their opportunities to collaborate with an armed group would have been greatly reduced, and they likely would not have been eligible for reintegration. Looking for the names of rebel groups and high-ranked commanders they described interacting with further helped establish the nature of individuals' involvement.

Sampling also drew on the maximum variation strategy, which involves identifying "cases or individuals who cover the spectrum of positions and perspectives in relation to the phenomenon one is studying" (Palys, 2008). This reflects my interest in ensuring FFCs are not portrayed as a homogenous cohort, and highlighting how their intersecting identities may have

impacted their experience with reintegration. Testimonies representing FFCs’ diversity in the following characteristics were thus sought out where available: armed group membership; role in armed group; age at recruitment; education status and field; LGBTQI+ self-identification; self-identification as disabled; Indigenous and/or ethnic minority status; and community type (such as rural or urban). Including such diversity supports the accurate representation of challenges faced by FFCs whose roles and intersecting identities within the conflict may have impacted their experiences.

All Sierra Leonean documents were originally published in English, including testimonies. Colombian documents were published in either English or Spanish, and all CEV testimonies were collected in Spanish. For all media originally published in Spanish, English translations provided by the publisher were used for consistency.

5.1.3 Analysis

This research uses a hybrid deductive-inductive approach to analysis. The study begins from an expectation grounded in existing literature that the theoretical frames of “Mothers, Monsters, Whores” and “womenandchildren” will be used in institutional documents to explain FFCs’ involvement in conflict, with FFCs’ testimonies expected to provide a more diverse perspective on their lived realities of conflict. Initial codes for analysis are informed by this theoretical approach. Balancing this theoretical backdrop with an inductive approach in turn allows for new themes to emerge from the sampled institutional documents and testimonies. This is important based on the understanding that FFCs’ identities, realities, and experiences with DDR are multiple, dynamic, and subjective. The cases are further embedded in distinct cultural, temporal, and geographical contexts, and may thus frame and discuss key concepts differently. Using a hybrid approach thus allows the study to be both theoretically informed and sensitive to the specificity of each case. *Figure 5* provides an overview of the codes used. The table includes both policy-implementation and framing codes. In some instances, codes may also overlap.

Figure 5

Coding Table

Code	Indicators in institutional documents	Indicators in testimonies	Policy relevance

Victim framing	FFC engagement described mainly as involuntary, framed as vulnerable, subordinate.	FFCs discuss violence inflicted on themselves and/or loved ones, coercion.	Risks reducing agency and coinciding motivations.
Perpetrator/agent framing	FFCs discussed in terms of political aspirations, voluntary engagement in violence, leadership.	FFCs discuss political and/or ideological motivations, holding leadership roles, committing violence.	Facilitates transitional justice, accountability, tailored reintegration plans.
“womenandchildren”	Care for adult women discussed in tandem with children’s or as facilitated by children’s agencies.	Adult women describe feeling invisible, not taken seriously.	May remove FFCs’ access to appropriate resources, particularly for perpetrators.
“Mothers”	Women discussed in terms of their obligation to children, other dependents, community members.	Women discuss their caring responsibilities.	Risks obscuring other motivations for conflict engagement.
“Monsters”	Violent acts of FFCs depicted as deviant, rooted in psychological abnormality.	FFCs describe rationalised reasoning for violence, feeling disassociated.	May facilitate psychological support, risks obscuring other motivations.
“Whores”	FFCs’ sexuality, intimate relationships with men described as motivating violence.	FFCs describe conflict participation in relation to male partners, friends, family.	May facilitate psychological support, risks obscuring other motivations.
Reintegration services	Discuss childcare, healthcare, education, vocational training, including gender-sensitive approaches.	Describe inadequate gender-sensitivity, limited agency, incomplete or inconsistent resources.	Suggests implementation gap.
Service provision	Suggests community measures provide adequate support.	Discuss non-existence or insufficiency of community resources.	Suggests need for capacity building and closer coordination.

Social reintegration	Account for stigma, retributive violence, reconciliation, community engagement.	Discuss bullying, isolation, exile, leadership, community engagement.	Demonstrates need for community monitoring, education around stigma.
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5.2 Case selection

5.2.1 Rationale

Sierra Leone and Colombia were selected as case studies due to the importance of the WPS agenda in their DDR processes. Both cases have received attention due to the high number of women participating and taking on varied roles in conflict, and have been commended for their gender-sensitivity. In both countries, FFCs constituted 30% to 40% of collaborators (Mazurana & Carlson, 2004; Gutiérrez & Murphy, 2022). These cases should, in turn, display greater recognition of challenges uniquely faced by FFCs and exemplify greater alignment with the WPS agenda as compared to cases where women's engagement has been lower.

As one of the earliest cases to integrate WPS, Sierra Leone's third DDR phase drew attention to FFCs' roles and experiences during conflict. As victims, FFCs drew attention to the widespread, systematic use of GBSV as a weapon of war, particularly due to its disproportionate impact on girls (Ben-Ari, 2014). As perpetrators, their engagement in the conflict contributed to a growing consciousness of women's ability to inflict violence to a degree equal to male collaborators, with some of the most horrific acts reported by victims having been perpetrated by women or on their command (Cheve, 2023). The DDR process has been applauded for its role in supporting FFCs by integrating stronger gender-sensitive measures, although questions remain about its long-term efficacy (Ade-Alamu, 2024).

Colombia's most recent DDR process provides a valuable point of comparison for several reasons. Since it is ongoing, the process is an important reference for what changes have been made on paper and in practice in the 25 years since UNSCR 1325 was passed. The process has received similar praise to that enjoyed by Sierra Leone regarding its gender-sensitivity, though whether inclusive principles have translated into meaningful action is a point of contention between scholars and practitioners (see, for instance, UN Women, 2025; GIWPS, 2025). Colombian FFCs were vital to and widely represented across armed groups, with the case receiving significant attention due to groups' gender-equal structures and FFCs' participation in traditionally male roles (Gutiérrez & Murphy, 2022; CEV, 2022). Combined with the mixed

reviews their representation in DDR has received from policymakers and scholars, the scope and scale of FFC participation provides the cases with a solid foundation for comparative analysis.

Selecting Sierra Leone and Colombia as case studies also supports the originality of and contribution made by this thesis. While comparative studies are not rare in conflict studies, it is much less common to see a comparison of cases taking place in highly distinct regional and temporal contexts. This allows this thesis to provide unique insight into which barriers to FFCs' reintegration may stay consistent or differ across contexts. Particularly where consistencies are identified, findings may increase confidence in their ability to accurately inform DDR policy and make recommendations about what targeted measures can best support FFCs' reintegration.

5.2.2 Limitations

A vital component of feminist theory is inclusivity based on the ontological standpoint that social realities are constructed in unequal sociopolitical-economic circumstances; as such, my intention in this research is to ensure my sample is representative of diverse FFCs and their experiences (Ackerly et al., 2006). However, in the context of a comparative study using highly distinct case studies, this becomes difficult due to data limitations and differences in convention. For instance, while Indigeneity and ethnicity were vital to the CEV's work, as their consideration is central to domestic sociolegal convention, they were given limited weight by the SLTRC (Restrepo, 2024; Momoh, 2023). This was largely due to the perception that since the conflict was politically motivated, considering identity-based factors was unnecessary (Millar, 2012). While the SLTRC is not known to have deliberately marginalised the voices of these populations, this discrepancy in access to information must be noted.

Similarly, while both cases reference the unique circumstances of rural women, this was given more weight in Colombia. This was in part due to the intersection of rural and Indigenous populations in Colombia, but also connected to geographical differences between the countries, where Colombia's land size is approximately 16 times that of Sierra Leone. Practically, this means that while both groups faced distinct challenges, these difficulties presented themselves differently and held distinct meanings, which must be communicated and accounted for when conducting a comparative analysis (Suárez-Baquero et al., 2022; Martin, 2021).

Legal differences also impact the countries' respective data collection. Same-sex relations were legalised in Colombia in the same year as the signing of the peace agreement, which supported the CEV's (2022) decision to highlight LGBTQI+ perspectives (HRW, 2016).

Comparable data was not collected by the SLTRC, however, as same-sex relations remain criminalised (Abifarin & Chijioke, 2016). During their respective DDR processes, legal conventions around childhood and youth also differed. In Sierra Leone, the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) was not incorporated into domestic law until 2007 (UNHCR Refworld, 2007). Until this date, definitions of childhood varied significantly based upon ethnic groups' customary law. In contrast, both the CRC and Optional Protocol on the involvement of children in armed conflict were ratified by Colombia prior to the initiation of DDR (UN Treaty Body, 2025). This is important to consider when analysing the experiences of young women and girls in each case.

While some may argue that in cases such as this where variable data is missing from one case study, it is best to exclude these categories from analysis, an approach known as Complete-Case Analysis (Little et al., 2022), I see this as incompatible with my research design. Following a post-positivist epistemological approach, I view the realities of FFCs as subjective, multiple, and dynamic rather than reducible to an objective, singular, or static truth (Peterson, 1992). Adding a feminist lens, this means that for this research to fulfil its objectives, FFCs' diverse realities must be upheld and addressed. To achieve this, I follow the methodological approach outlined by Tickner (2006), which asserts the importance of developing a framework under which biases and homogenisations are challenged to expose the variance of women and their lived realities. As such, diverse representation will be prioritised, including where variable data is unavailable for one case.

It should also not go unnoticed that testimonies collected by the SLTRC and CEV are not raw, neutral lived experiences, but rather mediated and influenced by the countries' transitional justice institutions and elites. Scholars such as van den Berg (2023) demonstrate that TRCs do not always reflect or do equal justice to the experiences of all former collaborators, with those considered "ordinary" feeling silenced or ignored. Relatedly, testimonies were collected by two separate institutions using distinct processes, which may lead to certain information being marginalised in one case and inflated in another. The CEV (2022) for instance collected testimonies in a narrative style, which may lead to a broader understanding of FFCs' journeys throughout the conflict and DDR process, whereas the SLTRC (2004a; 2004b) used an unstructured interview format, which may have pushed FFCs to speak more about specific

aspects of their experience which commissioners felt were particularly important at the expense of potentially pertinent information.

Considering the above limitations, the findings of this research remain well-positioned to support comparative conclusions related to FFCs' experiences in Sierra Leone and Colombia. The temporal and geographical differences between the cases support more generalisable findings by boosting the external validity of the study. However, the sample size and differences in available materials constrain the study's ability to make broad conclusions about different demographics or groups of FFCs. The reality that testimonies were collected by separate institutions with distinct approaches further constrains the ability of the study to make conclusive arguments in a manner comparable to a study able to ask the same questions in the same format and environment.

5.3 Ethical Considerations and Positionality

5.3.1 Ethics in Conflict Research

Ethical and security risks are impossible to fully remove from conflict research. While they are markedly mitigated here as research will be conducted remotely and FFCs will not be directly engaged, it remains essential to acknowledge and account for potential dangers.

Sufficient anonymisation of participants' personal details is vital across research fields. In conflict studies, this is particularly important where the release of witnesses' identities may lead to their targeting through retributive violence, forced disappearance, and other forms of persecution (Adamska-Gallant, 2024). Anonymisation can be challenging when using existing sources based on varying jurisdictional regulations (Windon & Youngblood, 2024). In this case, both the SLTRC and CEV have chosen to release identifying information about people who provided testimony, including in some instances their full names, localities, and ages. While some cases declare that identifying information has been altered for security, it is unclear how consistently and thoroughly this was done. To ensure the security of the FFCs whose testimonies are analysed, FFCs have been assigned a code to replace their name. Sierra Leonean FFCs will be referred to as 'SLx' and Colombian as 'COx', where 'x' will be replaced by a number between 1 and 12. Additional identifying details, such as the names of cities or towns and FFCs' ages will be replaced with something more generalised. For instance, the location 'Rosint' may be replaced with [Bombali district], or the age '14' may be replaced with [child]. While

un-anonymised information may still be retrieved from online databases, these measures provide a layer of security and ensure compliance with my local regulations.

Security and ethical concerns are reduced for Sierra Leone based on the country's consistent political stability in the decades since the cessation of violence. While social tensions remain, and there have been some violent relapses, all such periods have been brief and relatively well-contained (Njolinbi & Rigiderakhshan, 2025). This reduces the risk of retribution posed to individuals in the event they were identified through the original, un-anonymised SLTRC records.

Concerns in Colombia are slightly elevated due to the increased prevalence of violence, including in previously stable regions, since 2023 (HIIK, 2024). It is not unlikely that this could increase further in 2026 due to the country's upcoming election cycle, an event which has historically led to heightened tensions and violence (UNSC, 2025b). This again indicates the importance of ensuring proper data anonymisation to limit the likelihood that information presented in this thesis could directly be used to identify and target FFCs. While it will never be possible to entirely eliminate the possibility of information falling into ill-meaning hands, including purely based on the fact that it is publicly available on the internet independently of its presentation in this thesis, the above measures limit the chances that its publication would directly support the targeting of any individuals or groups.

5.3.2 Researcher Positionality

As a researcher, I follow an approach to research which prioritises co-creation, non-extractivity, and the minimisation of unequal power relations between the researcher and population of interest, in keeping with recommendations made by Jenkins et al. (2019). In the context of this thesis, this refers to my commitment to the ethical use and accurate representation of gathered data and its depictions of FFCs' experiences, and the practice of reflexivity, a process involving ongoing critical self-reflection around how my identity and biases may impact my interpretation and communication of data. With this in mind, researchers such as Cheve (2023) often argue for fieldwork-driven research and other methods emphasising person-to-person interaction. Given that the primary research for this thesis takes place remotely, it will follow Kingston's (2020) approach of doing research *for* the population of interest, meaning in this case ensuring that conclusions and recommendations drawn from this research are positioned such that they can be used to support current and future FFCs' reintegration experiences.

These principles, and my positionality in relation to them, are vital in a context where my ability to conduct this research alone is indicative of an uneven power relation. Conflict is known to cause or exacerbate barriers to education, particularly for women and girls (Bell & Huebler, 2011). In Sierra Leone, this contributed to the literacy rate for women being under 30% at the end of the conflict, and in Colombia, girls born around the same year as myself received on average 2-3 years of formal education by the age of 15 (Republic of Sierra Leone, 2006; Bell & Huebler, 2011). My own reality of growing up in a peaceful, highly-educated, gender-equal society creates a power imbalance regarding my ability to conduct and disseminate research (OECD, 2024). Such dynamics place an obligation upon myself to communicate FFCs' experiences in a way which maintains their humanity and dignity. Sensationalism and victimisation are common in depictions of non-Western women, and contribute to the perpetuation of (neo-)colonial stereotyping and homogenisation (Mohanty, 2003). Reflexivity here is vital, necessitating my ongoing reflection about whether I am inadvertently perpetuating tokenising or essentialising imaginaries of FFCs.

6. Results

6.1 How are FFCs in each case framed in institutional discourse?

6.1.1 *Sierra Leone*

Sierra Leonean FFCs were largely framed as victims and non-participants in the conflict across the sampled institutional documents. Where it was suggested that FFCs had engaged in conflict, their participation was framed in terms of coercion. The most common tool used to construct women in this way was the discussion of their realities and needs almost always appearing alongside those of children, in line with the “womenandchildren” frame. This was particularly clear when examining how services for women were positioned in tandem with those for children. The strongest references to official, targeted support for women were found in the UN Secretary General’s reports, often under sections on child protection or children’s rights, including in documents which had subheadings on women’s rights.⁵ A report issued in March 2002, for instance, states that “[g]roups of abducted women... have started to participate in community-based reintegration projects initiated by child protection agencies”.⁶

In the cases where women were discussed as actively participating in conflict, their participation was nearly always discussed as unarmed, and it was suggested that they were lower-ranked than male collaborators. Considering this alongside SL-SG2’s definition of DDR’s success as contingent on weapons reduction suggests inconsistencies around what, in the eyes of practitioners, defined individuals’ reintegration eligibility. Relatedly, there was limited discussion of tailored, gender-sensitive reintegration across the institutional documents, with only a few references to childcare, healthcare, education, and vocational training. Social reintegration was not discussed in relation to former collaborators, though the concept was raised throughout SL-SG1, SL-RES1, SL-SG3, and SL-SG4 as critical for refugees and internally displaced persons. The need for greater gender-sensitive measures targeting women who had not participated in reintegration was raised in SL-SG2, which states that “the Mission’s human rights officers and the Child Protection Adviser provide [gender awareness] training to the peacekeepers as part of their induction”. While gender-sensitivity training is important, this framing implies that it focussed more heavily on human rights abuses and children’s rights rather than positioning women on an equal footing to other collaborators.

⁵ SL-SG1; SL-SG2; SL-SG3.

⁶ Quote from SL-SG2.

Sierra Leonean documents did not account for stigma and retributive violence faced by (re-)inserted FFCs. DDR was overall praised, as seen in SL-MSIL1's review of their family reunification, vocational training, and financial support programmes. A short note at the end of SL-MSIL1 makes such praise, or at least its sustainability, questionable, stating "[t]he success in disarming and demobilizing combatants was not equally matched with efforts to reintegrate and find them decent jobs... unless the economy generates more jobs, the presence of former fighters roaming the streets will continue to be one of the Government's major challenges". SL-RES2 similarly discusses concerns related to the reintegration process, responding to reports that UNAMSIL personnel were perpetrating sexual violence against FFCs. In neither case was this acknowledgement matched by a meaningful discussion of solutions.

6.1.2 Colombia

The participation of Colombian women in conflict was mainly framed in terms of coercion. FFCs continued to be framed largely as victims, with minimal reference to female perpetrators. This was most often done by constructing women's engagement during and after the conflict as falling under one of two 'extreme' categories. On one side, a pattern emerges where discussions focus nearly exclusively on women, alongside children, as victims. For instance, discussing recent upticks in violence, CO-SC2 makes the strongest condemnation of FFCs' treatment across the sampled documents. The report draws attention to the various roles held by collaborators without placing more or less value on any in terms of necessitating individuals' transition to civilian life. What warrants attention in this context is that the statement was made by the Working Group on Children in Armed Conflict. This is not to suggest the group is unqualified to assess the condition and treatment of FFCs or that their advocacy is damaging, however the fact that it provides the strongest recognition of FFCs' lived realities indicates a reliance on "womenandchildren".

The other "extreme" appears more in relation to FFCs' post-conflict realities, entailing their framing as a uniformly exceptional group of leaders. Such framings tend to highlight the work of female leaders, portraying them as caretakers and advocates for the rights of other women in line with the frame of "Mothers". This is exemplified by CO-FEM1, which proclaims the Colombian peace agreement to be "[t]he peace deal that put women first" thanks to the comprehensive engagement of women's rights activists. The binary between this extreme and that of "womenandchildren" is seen clearly in CO-SC3, which states early on that "'it was not

pre-ordained that Colombia's peace process would set a global standard for the inclusion of women in a peace process". This happened only because Colombian women's leaders demanded that it be so." Later in the document, however, the Government of Colombia is urged to "ensur[e] that women and girls are kept outside the conflict"⁷ which aligns more with the "womenandchildren" frame by constructing women's engagement in conflict as concerning in the same way as children's, rather than a rationalised decision.

Colombian documents thoroughly recognised FFCs' right to reintegration, and displayed some nuance in their portrayal of women's experiences with the process. There was also some recognition that FFCs face stigma and retributive violence. CO-SG2, for instance, provides gender-disaggregated data on retributive violence across Colombian regions, stating that "[m]ost of these killings have stemmed from disputes among armed groups over territorial control and... the stigmatization of former combatants". There was similar recognition of ongoing challenges relating to collaborators' access to material services, with CO-SC2 expressing "concern at the armed strikes conducted by armed groups... preventing the supply of food, fuel and access to health care or educational services." The report did maintain that support remained available, if restricted.

Notably, discussions of what gender-sensitive, targeted resources are available specifically to FFCs are extremely limited. There is ample discussion of the importance of engagement with women and women's groups to ensure their needs are met, but there are rarely indications of how their outcomes will support women's reintegration. CO-SG1 for instance states that the UN Mission in Colombia "remained closely engaged with women's groups to exchange information on the gender dimension of peace implementation" but otherwise only speaks of Colombian women as victims of GBSV.

6.2 How do FFCs' lived realities reflect or diverge from these findings?

6.2.1 Sierra Leone

Sierra Leonean FFCs' testimonies display a range of motivations and experiences related to their participation in armed groups. The majority reported being coerced into conflict. One motivating factor was identified by FFCs despite not being recognised in the sampled institutional documents, that being their legitimisation of participation vis-à-vis pre-existing relationships. In contrast to the uneven power dynamic between male and female collaborators

⁷ Quote from CO-SC3.

often depicted at the institutional level, FFCs used this frame to explain how friends, family, and colleagues exposed them to the plans and ideologies of their armed groups, and how their resonance with these ideas led to their mobilisation. SL8 for instance describes learning about the conflict from relatives before choosing independently how to engage. Most FFCs reported that themselves and other women held roles equal to those of men, with minimal indication that women were superior or subordinate to men. FFCs in Sierra Leone were described as perpetrating violence through financial extortion⁸, calumny⁹, and sexual humiliation.¹⁰

The majority of FFCs recognised that themselves and/or other women had perpetrated violence, but simultaneously recognised that they had been victims. Very few reported that themselves or other FFCs they encountered held armed roles, although testimonies made clear that weapons were not the only means through which collaborators inflicted violence. SL7, for instance, describes escaping captivity, having been held by rebels under the command of her stepmother. After fleeing, she discusses her stepmother ordering rebels to find her, stating her survival had only been possible because “the rebels were in sympathy with me because we spoke the same language, they... even showed me the knife which my stepmother had given them to kill me.”¹¹

FFCs described mixed experiences of reintegration support. A small majority expressed that they had not received support. The question of services offered versus desired was raised by SLTRC commissioners at the end of each testimony, with some FFCs mentioning receiving gender-sensitive healthcare and vocational training. Nearly all FFCs, however, still expressed that they lacked necessities such as tools to implement their vocational training, primary education, or sufficient childcare and funds to support their dependents. There were some references to support offered voluntarily by FFCs’ families, as described here by SL7:

“Commissioner: Who is responsible for your education?”

SL7: My mother.

Commissioner: Have you met anybody who would be in place to help you?

SL7: No.

Commissioner: Will your mother be able to take care of your education right through?

⁸ SL3.

⁹ SL7.

¹⁰ SL5.

¹¹ SL7.

SL7: I don't know, but she is trying her best."¹²

Those who discussed social reintegration reported experiencing stigma and retributive violence. SL2 describes the toll taken on her by stigma and insufficient reintegration support, stating "[p]eople state that I'm mad. I can't eat. People should not be taunted; it is not good to taunt people."¹³

6.2.2 Colombia

The testimonies of Colombian FFCs illustrated significant variation in their pathways into conflict and experiences of being a collaborator. Women nearly equally reported joining an armed group through coercion or in connection to a pre-existing relationship, such as a friend or family member, with slightly fewer expressing a political motivation. The majority of FFCs saw themselves as both victims and perpetrators. There was considerable discussion of FFCs holding armed roles, though most described themselves and other women having unarmed roles. Former EPL member CO3 described FFCs' (un)armed participation by stating "There weren't many women in the EPL. One of them was very courageous, she used weapons."¹⁴

A significant number of Colombian FFCs framed their participation as non-coercive, but in relation to pre-existing relationships. CO1, for instance, recounts that when her family was unable to continue paying for her education, her partner gave her school supplies and supported her decision to join an armed group as a means to pay for her school fees. CO3 provides another perspective, stating that hearing her brother speak about the importance of the EPL's mission in her youth was what made her enthusiastic about joining herself. Adding to this argument, CO7 states "I joined the M-19 because I know I have to be a member of an organisation that transforms this country's reality," constructing a clear image of her rationalised political engagement. These accounts recentre FFCs' agency in consciously deciding to join armed groups, even where the idea may have been sparked by someone else.

In Colombia, the majority of FFCs described having minimal or no access to reintegration services, with support often attributed to community groups organised by their peers and/or themselves. Several reported being given access to institutionally-coordinated disarmament and demobilisation, but subsequently lacking access to reintegration,¹⁵

¹² SL7.

¹³ SL2.

¹⁴ CO3.

¹⁵ CO2, CO3, CO8, CO10.

consequently feeling “[they] are made invisible.”¹⁶ As interviews followed a narrative format rather than being recorded as a back-and-forth conversation as in the Sierra Leonean case, where FFCs were directly asked what support they had received, it is possible that some Colombian FFCs did not naturally bring up reintegration services in the course of their conversations.

However, the manner in which most FFCs discussed their post-conflict realities, often in terms of serious mental health concerns, ruptured familial and community relationships, and feeling constantly under threat of persecution strongly suggests that even if this was the case, support was insufficient. Sentiments around fear and social discomfort were present in the vast majority of testimonies, suggesting the pervasive presence of stigma and retribution, including one individual who was forced to flee the country due to the persecution of herself and her children.¹⁷ One FFC, an Indigenous leader, had a different experience, noting feeling welcomed back by her community.¹⁸

Many also express that while still holding concerns, they would welcome opportunities to speak with FFCs from different backgrounds to better understand each other’s needs and perspectives. This is summarised by former AUC member CO5 who states “[w]e need to stop thinking that we can’t work with women who think differently. We need to start working together.” Her perspective was notably inspired by her time working on the gender sub-commission, to which she was assigned after initially accompanying her boss during the peace process for other reasons. CO5 describes being reassigned following public complaints about insufficient gender-sensitive measures. While reflecting that she later realised she had subconsciously employed a gendered lens to her reality throughout her life, CO5 notes lacking previous experience in the field.

¹⁶ CO8.

¹⁷ CO3.

¹⁸ CO11.

7. Discussion

*“These wars and this violence have been against many leading women. There is no peace agreement. That is a lie... I believe that war continues.”*¹⁹

7.1 Where do policy-relevant gaps appear when contrasting Sierra Leone and Colombia?

Considering that these cases take place decades apart and are separated by consistent developments to the WPS agenda, their comparison may be expected to show considerable difference in both institutional rhetoric around FFCs’ experiences and their testimonies. The reality, however, remains more inconsistent. In both cases, institutional documents demonstrate a reliance on the “womenandchildren” frame, where FFCs’ participation is constructed around their childlike manipulability and dependence on, rather than participation as, collaborators. FFCs, of course, can be dependent on collaborators, for instance a parent, but overreliance on this framing can unfairly imply its applicability to *all* FFCs. As discussed above in relation to SL-SG2, this often takes the form of assigning women’s care to children’s aid agencies, which may limit their access to appropriate resources. Those not fitting this template are most often portrayed as “Mothers” through the emphasis of nurturing traits and leadership post-conflict. Rarely do such depictions account for the realities of “Mothers” during conflict or how this may impact their needs as individuals. The inadequacy of such frames is made clear through FFC testimonies, which highlight women’s agency and the reality that most cannot be neatly sorted into groups of “victims” or “perpetrators”.

In Sierra Leone, an argument that FFCs lacked access to sufficient resources is supported by testimonies, which suggest some difference between age groups. SL11 notes that her stepdaughter, who spent her formative years being held by and forced to participate in an armed group, received healthcare through reintegration, and was continuing to receive community support. Another child recruit, SL6, recounted receiving healthcare and vocational training to become a hairdresser in the immediate aftermath of the conflict. However, stating “I do not have peaceful nights because I am always thinking of my hairdressing tools”, SL6 describes ongoing psychological and financial distress rooted in the fact that she was not provided the materials or financial resources to which she was entitled. This rendered the skills she learned unusable, leading her to beg for money for subsistence.

¹⁹ Quote from CO6.

Older women such as SL2 reported receiving no reintegration despite facing health concerns, retributive violence, and having a limited support system due to the deaths of her children and grandchildren. SL9 and SL12 each relatedly reported that, having become the sole caretakers for their respective siblings' children after their deaths, neither had been offered support. This left their families struggling to survive, as SL9 summarises by stating “[o]ur community had been destroyed by the rebels; no school, no road; our goods are perishing.”

By the third phase of Sierra Leone's DDR process, UNSCR 1325 had articulated that practitioners in post-conflict spaces should be trained on and provided materials necessary to understand and support “[t]he special needs of women and girls during repatriation and resettlement and for rehabilitation, reintegration and post-conflict reconstruction” (UNSC, 2000). UNSCR 1325 further establishes responsibility of “all those involved in the planning for disarmament, demobilization and reintegration to consider the different needs of female and male ex-combatants and to take into account the needs of their dependants” (UNSC, 2000). SL-SG2 describes personnel in Sierra Leone receiving such training, however what this would practically entail for FFCs was unspecified. FFC testimonies support the suggestion that a gap remained between knowledge of best practice and the ability to adequately reach and support women.

Sierra Leone was an early case of WPS implementation, which theoretically made any areas of concern a strong learning opportunity for future practitioners. The Colombian case is ongoing, but progress to date suggests a persistent gap between knowledge of FFCs' realities and action taken to ensure they receive equitable support. While continuing to largely frame FFCs as “womenandchildren” or “Mothers”, there is increased, though still limited, acknowledgement that FFCs are agentic and may have political and ideological motivations for engaging in conflict. Importantly, such recognition did not depict FFCs under the limiting frames of “Monsters” or “Whores”. This is vital for their ability to access DDR, as it constructs them within the same space as any other former collaborator.

At the same time, this was not reflected in more meaningful discussions of what gender inclusive reintegration practically means for FFCs. Comparing Colombian institutional documents and testimonies to those from Sierra Leone shows decreased reference to specific gender-sensitive reintegration measures, particularly childcare, education, and vocational training. While recognition that women are entitled to DDR and may need distinct support is important, failing to match such statements with recognition of the issues women may uniquely

face and how to address them demonstrates only symbolic recognition without facilitating substantive support.

FFC testimonies build on the suggestion that greater recognition of their existence has not translated into more attention to their distinct needs. Several Colombian women reported accessing mainstream disarmament and demobilisation before being referred ambiguously to community-based resources rather than continuing in reintegration. FFCs further recount that no community-based resources existed. This is exemplified by CO2, who was kidnapped by an armed group as a university student and spent ten years in combat. Despite having no qualification or experience in the field, having previously trained in visual arts, CO2 was forced after being demobilised to open her own community organisation to support the reintegration of herself and fellow FFCs.

Comparing Sierra Leonean and Colombian institutional documents and testimonies thus suggests that a gap persists between the improved knowledge of FFCs' realities and needs and the development of resources which facilitate their equitable support. It is particularly relevant to consider here the participatory element of the WPS agenda, which theoretically establishes a normative basis for greater coordination between FFCs and institutions, raising alarms where weaknesses appear and facilitating policy refinement. UNSCR 2122 emphasises this, stating “persisting barriers to full implementation of resolution 1325 (2000) will only be dismantled through dedicated commitment to women’s empowerment, participation... consistent information and action, and support” (UNSC, 2013). UNSCR 2493 further emphasises the necessity of “provisions to facilitate women’s full and effective participation and protection in... disarmament, demobilization and reintegration programs” (UNSC, 2019).

Together, these contextualise the issues FFCs continue describing by highlighting an existing awareness about the need for consistent coordination and targeted support during DDR. In FFC testimonies from both cases, women clearly articulate their needs, desires, and the avenues through which they have sought support, but persistently express facing barriers which impact their ability to sustainably reintegrate due to financial strain, mental or physical health, and lack of resources like childcare. The reality that despite the development of such policies, there does not appear to be significant evolution between how Sierra Leonean and Colombian women described experiencing reintegration in their testimonies, which were collected 18 years apart, points to a policy-relevant gap between WPS objectives and their practical translation into

post-conflict contexts. The reality that policy progress does not appear to consistently be reflected in FFCs' experiences further supports an argument in favour of greater case-specificity and co-constitution to balance known best practices with the realities FFCs actively face in a given post-conflict context.

7.2 How do these results fit into the existing literature?

The results of this study contribute to and build on the existing literature in several areas. First, its findings suggest that the dynamism of FFCs' roles in conflict are not adequately recognised, as institutional documents persistently use the "womenandchildren" and "Mothers" frames. As discussed above, one instance where this was clearly visible was document CO-SC3, which highlighted exceptional developments supported by women leaders, contrasted to the hypervulnerability of women and girls continuing to experience conflict. This constructs a binary juxtaposing "Mothers" who work tirelessly to nurture and advocate for those at risk while themselves remaining safely away from danger, and the "womenandchildren" whose continued proximity to conflict renders them hypervulnerable. While it is vital to include both of these perspectives, their emphasis as presented in the sampled documents comes at the expense of "ordinary" collaborators. This builds on van den Berg's (2023) study of "ordinary" collaborators' access to transitional justice, which suggests these individuals constitute the majority of armed group members, yet receive the least attention during transitional justice.

Viewing FFCs through the "womenandchildren" frame is particularly problematic in this way, as it highlights problems and vulnerability experienced by women without paying equal attention to their agency during and after conflict. Children involved in conflict, again, are automatically considered victims under international law (UN, 2017). Depictions of "womenandchildren" are thus harmful as they construct adult women within the same space without considering that they may have been perpetrators, whose care during reintegration follows a different format (UN, 2022). This builds on Poehlman and Hill's (2001) assertion that equating women and children's positions in conflict facilitates women's marginalisation from political participation and the right to make decisions about their own lives based on their construction as vulnerable and helpless. Puechguirbal (2005) extends this argument to illustrate how such depictions perpetuate harmful gendered stereotypes and justify their continued exclusion from discussions of peace and security to which UNSCR 1325 was intended to grant them access.

Reflecting on the reality that there were fewer references to specific gender-sensitive reintegration measures in Colombian than Sierra Leonean documents even though Colombian documents showed greater recognition of FFCs' need for reintegration suggests the use of an "add women and stir" approach, rather than a more co-constitutive, equitable method. This is further indicated by CO5's experience on the gender sub-commission, which was composed of seven women, and to which she describes being suddenly reassigned despite having no academic or professional experience in the field (UNSC, 2017). This could be seen as a positive, in view of Thomas' (2024) argument that including ordinary FFCs' voices is virtually the only way to ensure adequate provisions for their DDR are made, particularly those recognising violent women and their needs during reintegration. On the other hand, using "add women and stir" rather than meaningfully balancing FFCs' input with the leadership of trained, experienced personnel may restrict the group's capacity to develop sustainable measures (McCulloch, 2020).

7.3 Why does this gap matter?

Possibly the most concerning potential outcome of persistent insufficiencies in the reintegration support offered to FFCs relates to the likelihood of violent relapse. Socioeconomic indicators such as feeling rejected or threatened by one's community and peers, lacking a support system, being unable to find sustainable and fulfilling employment, and feeling dejected due to losing the rank or status held within an armed group are all known to contribute to former collaborators' decision to re-join armed groups, potentially leading to the destabilisation of peace (Collier et al., 2003). This threat highlights the importance of reintegration, which is meant to directly address these concerns. Importantly, this is an intergenerational risk, meaning that insufficient support to one generation could lead to conflict between the next (Kuppens & Langer, 2023).

When unable to access reintegration tailored to their unique experiences, FFCs may be left without the socioeconomic resources needed to lead safe, comfortable livelihoods. This is particularly true in protracted conflicts, as applies to both Sierra Leone and Colombia. For instance, women and girls already face disproportionate barriers to education, which are heightened during conflict (Bell & Huebler, 2011). This is most acutely felt by those recruited as children who lost the years of primary school they may otherwise have accessed; as an example, Sierra Leonean girls as young as two years of age were kidnapped by armed groups and placed in active combat as young as seven (Betancourt et al., 2010). The practical and professional skills

they are then able to learn as part of the education and vocational training to which they should have access during reintegration become vital to ensure a non-violent livelihood is possible.

On the side of social reintegration, stigma was heavily emphasised as something FFCs in both cases were concerned about, as was loss of status. This was particularly the case in Colombia, and was discussed markedly more in testimonies than institutional documents. This aspect uniquely highlights the inadequacy of equating women's experiences to children's, rather than framing them as rational and agentic adults. As discussed above, FFCs largely described no gender-based hierarchy in armed groups. This contributes to a reality erased from institutional discourse around the struggle they had returning to civilian livelihood. One FARC-EP FFC states "I was a militant for 20 years in the FARC, and the participation and experience I had in the FARC in terms of gender equality was maybe 50 or 100 years ahead of this society" (Pauls et al., 2023). This suggests that the complexity of women's engagement in conflict continues to be a discursive 'blind spot' from an institutional perspective and, when contextualised by the known correlation between socioeconomic dissatisfaction and likelihood of violent relapse, constitutes a potentially damaging disjuncture between reality and rhetoric.

In assessing both cases, it is worth returning to the reality that these are not raw, unmediated experiences, and cannot possibly provide a longitudinal assessment of what changes, positive or negative, presented themselves after the collection and publication of these testimonies. In Sierra Leone, commissioners repeatedly expressed that recommendations and pleas for support would be passed along to appropriate personnel. While such offers may have been sidelined or addressed unequally due to their volume, it is equally possible that they were eventually realised. Ascertaining this would be incredibly difficult, as it would require identifying each individual whose testimony was analysed and relying on their memory of what services they were offered, by whom, and when over the last 22 years since the SLTRC concluded. In Colombia, while we know the implementation of gender-sensitive measures outlined in the 2016 peace process has been minimal (see, for instance, GIWPS, 2025), the process is ongoing. While slow progress is not ideal, it should not be misunderstood as necessarily meaning that progress will never be made.

8. Conclusion

Overall, an analysis of institutional documents across both cases suggests that while policies have evolved under the WPS agenda, FFCs' framing in institutional accounts has not modernised to the same extent. This is particularly made clear when contextualised by FFCs' descriptions of their lived experiences. Together, these findings support an argument that the limited degree to which FFCs' discursive framing aligns in institutional accounts and individual testimonies supports their persistent marginalisation from equitable reintegration services. Continuing to largely frame women as victims contributes to the perception that they are not in need of the same support as perpetrators. The findings of this thesis indicate that this is most often operationalised through framing FFCs as "Mothers" (Sjoberg & Gentry, 2007) or "womenandchildren" (Enloe, 1990). Both lenses allow women to be constructed as hypervulnerable and innately peaceful rather than acknowledging their role in violence.

Categorising FFCs as victims without considering the other roles they may have played during conflict, including as perpetrators, can contribute to their inability to receive necessary support based on the UN's (2022) differing baseline for support to victims and perpetrators during DDR. The risk of inappropriate resource attribution is made clear by Collier et al.'s (2003) assertion that discontent with one's socioeconomic position post-conflict, which reintegration is directly intended to mitigate, constitutes a serious indicator for the likelihood of violent relapse. Kuppens and Langer's (2023) finding that failing to address such concerns can lead to their intergenerational transference, potentially contributing to violent relapse between the descendants of former adversaries, further illuminates this risk. This highlights the importance of taking an individualised approach to reintegration, which seeks to understand each individual's unique experiences during conflict, the physical and mental toll this has taken on them, and their responsibilities and wishes for life post-conflict.

Ensuring that resources and training attributed during reintegration have a sustainable, positive impact is further essential. Multiple FFCs discussed being offered vocational training or education post-conflict, but lacking the financial or physical tools necessary to implement their new skills. Returning to the example of SL6, who received training as a hairdresser but was denied the tools she required to practice her vocation, illustrates a policy gap, rendering the outcome of reintegration symbolic rather than substantive. This should further extend to social resources such as childcare, which FFCs repeatedly state is a barrier to their ability to access

education, vocational training, and employment. To ensure equitable reintegration access for all collaborators, childcare should be a mainstream consideration, not an add-on “women’s issue”. Under the definition used in this study, reintegration is a lifelong process. Without implementation resources, however, the long-term sustainability of any training opportunities is incredibly difficult.

This supports an argument in favour of stronger data and monitoring around reintegration implementation, particularly concerning indicators which are relevant distinctly to women. Childcare is, again, a strong example of this, where better data may be able to flag inadequacies to practitioners during the process rather than retroactively. Giving equal status in this way to topics often framed as optional “women’s issues” can further illuminate gaps left by an “add women and stir” approach which allows for women’s symbolic representation in DDR without substantive inclusion. Particularly as “third generation” DDR is intended to include both longer mission mandates and greater community-based capacity building, stronger data on relevant indicators could help FFCs receive more appropriate support, and support capacity building in targeting weak areas before the withdrawal of personnel.

An important step in this direction could begin with addressing the inadequacy of the “add women and stir” approach at all levels. In Colombia, for instance, CO5 reported sitting on the gender sub-commission despite being brought into the peace process for entirely different reasons and having no previous experience working on or studying gender issues. Diverse participation is vital and valuable, but findings such as the GIWPS’ (2025) which indicate under 15% of gender-sensitive measures have been implemented since 2016 make it worth considering and conducting further research on the adequacy of this approach. This is not to imply that the voices of “ordinary” FFCs are unimportant; they are inherently vital to ensure services are designed and implemented in line with their experiences. At the same time, relying on the voices of “ordinary” individuals as authoritative displays an “add women and stir” approach that should not be treated as a substitution for the leadership of trained, experienced personnel in possession of the authority, knowledge, and resources to implement measures aligning with both known best practices and contextual specificities.

Returning to Goebel and Levy’s (2020) reflection on the three generations of DDR, contemporary “third generation” processes theoretically entail greater partnership between international and local organisations to facilitate capacity building. This should allow policy to

align more closely with civilians' concerns and needs. The findings of this study raise questions in this area, however, with Colombian women reporting having to start their own organisations to reintegrate themselves. While it is not within the scope of this study to conclude on where a disconnect between international and local organisations may be occurring, this presents an interesting and important direction for future research. Such a study would benefit from closer engagement with policymakers, civilians, and community leaders to get a more accurate sense of where this breakdown is occurring.

Another limitation of this study is its inability to present a longitudinal assessment of whether individuals whose testimonies were collected were provided greater support in the years following their participation in the SLTRC or CEV. During the SLTRC, individuals providing testimony were prompted to state what support they would benefit from. It would be valuable to discuss with the same individuals whether and to what extent requests were realised. The CEV took place during DDR, which is still ongoing. This makes it possible that FFCs who previously discussed areas of need have been or will be allocated the resources they requested. This presents an additional important direction for future research. Such a study would likely benefit from fieldwork and closer, long-term engagement with FFCs. In addition to the question of whether and what changes have occurred over time, testimonies collected by TRCs are not neutral or unmediated by the responsible institutions, and it is impossible to ascertain if and what external pressures were placed on FFCs, whether they felt safe to speak openly, whether they had been coerced into providing inaccurate statements, and whether their statements were censored. Direct engagement with FFCs would not eliminate these and other concerns, but would provide more transparency around external conditions and how they may influence FFCs' assessments.

This study deliberately selected cases separated by their respective unique histories, geographies, cultures, and timelines, which boosts its external validity while also making an original contribution to a field in which most comparative studies examine more similar cases. All post-conflict contexts remain unique, however, and further research would help develop a robust understanding of where areas of strength and weakness are more constant, as well as where and why variation occurs.

Similarly, cases with higher women's participation were intentionally chosen. It would be valuable for future research to include cases where women's participation was lower. In light of the gaps highlighted by this study, it would be expected that barriers for women would be higher

in cases where they receive less attention. Understanding whether and to what extent this is true could strengthen an argument in favour of an individualised approach to reintegration for all collaborators. It would further be valuable to apply a similar methodology to male collaborators' experiences to determine whether and to what extent gaps in rhetoric and lived realities of their reintegration experiences diverge, and how any gaps in care are similar or different to those experienced by women.

Together, this study and the opportunities it presents for further research can contribute to the development of a more nuanced understanding of what it means to be a female collaborator. Discrepancies between FFCs' lived experiences and the accounts of institutions suggest a failure to listen to and support women's experiences and agency. Exploring the testimonies of FFCs indicates that they are ambitious and eager to engage in reintegration, yet struggle to do so when faced with a lack of appropriate resources. These findings point to new lenses through which DDR policymaking and the appraisal of WPS' integration should be considered in understanding the relevance various measures hold for their target populations.

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Appendix

I. Testimonies

I.i Sierra Leone

Code ²⁰	Document	Year	Source
SL1	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL2	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL3	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL4	Appendix 2: Submissions to the Sierra Leone Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC)	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL5	Appendix 2: Submissions to the Sierra Leone Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC)	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL6	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL7	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL8	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL9	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL10	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL11	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone
SL12	Appendix 3: Transcripts of TRC public hearings	2004	Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Sierra Leone

²⁰ Codes for testimonies are formatted as: [abbreviated country name + number].

I.ii Colombia

Code	Document	Year	Source
CO1	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO2	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO3	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO4	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO5	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO6	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO7	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO8	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO9	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO10	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO11	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición
CO12	Mujeres y personas lgbtiq	2022	Comisión para el Esclarecimiento de la Verdad, Convivencia y la No-repetición